

The candybars are generally the most easy to slip into a pocket. The W710i is designed to be strapped to your body, and has applications that monitor parameters such as speed and distance covered while jogging. The lone slider phone, the Nokia 5300, can neither be held comfortably nor can it be easily carried in the pocket.

At first glance, the heaviest phone in this category at 130 grams, the jet-black Nokia 3250, appears to be the most ruggedly-built, but once it's turned around, the flimsy plastic flap is revealed. The MotoKRZR K1 and the colourful Nokia 5300 are extremely rugged. The W710i is built well with a pearly white plastic body, but the hinges seem weak.

The Nokia 6131 has a spring-action, button-activated lid; it is rugged as long as it is closed, but once opened, it reveals its internal LCD without any glass protection, and you need to take special care of it.

Ease of use was a difficult parameter to gauge: each phone has its own interface, and ease of use just means getting used to it. We tried to gauge this from the point of view of a person handling the phone for the first time. The Nokias have the familiar Symbian-based interface, which is as easy as using Explorer in Windows. SE has its slick interface, which is also pretty easy to handle. Motorola's interface is not as intuitive as those of SE and Nokia.

The SE K550i is, concept-wise, similar to the hugely-successful K750i, but the keypad has been revamped, and not for the better. The K550i's keys are narrow bars which makes them not only uncomfortable, but also painful, as we experienced after typing in a few SMSes. The MotoKRZR has the flat keypad of MotoRAZR fame, a delight to use.

Basic Features

In India, GSM mobile signals are broadcast on two frequency bands, 900 MHz and 1800 MHz.

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Sony Ericsson CyberShot K550i

A Camera-mobile or a Mobile-camera?

Therefore, a dual-band phone is good enough to be used here. But if you travel abroad, you need a tri-band or even a quad-band. The Nokia 3250 and 5300 only support tri-band, while the rest support all four bands.

The SEs and Motorolas have a display resolution of 176 x 220; the Nokia 5300 and 6131 have higher resolutions of 240 x 320. Even with a large display, the Nokia 3250 still has an (odd) lower resolution of 176 x 208, which makes images look a bit pixelated. The Nokia 6131 is the only handset with 24-bit colour.

GPRS with EDGE are standard on all the phones, and allow you to connect to high-speed Internet (you can expect somewhere between 100 and 200 Kbps) while on the move. Nokia's 6131 and 5300 as well as the SE K550i boast of HSCSD (High-Speed Circuit-Switched Data), which allows up to 50 per cent higher throughput. This may not be important now with current speeds, but it could become significant as the offered speeds improve.

Expandable memory is the norm in mobile phones these days, and all the phones support some kind of memory expansion. microSD was the popular format with most phones, while SE prefers to go with Memory Stick M2. Only the Nokias featured hot-swappable memories, which lets you replace the memory card without the need to switch off the phone. Of these, the 6131 needs to be opened to access the memory slot, which takes away the convenience of hot-swappability. As has been the case with its predecessors, SE phones require a driver to be recognised as removable USB drives when connected to a PC.

The Camera

2-megapixel cameras were common—not so during our previous mobile phone shootout in this price category. Only the Nokia 5300 and 6131 came with 1.3-MP cameras and 8x zoom. The Nokia 3250 has a 270-degree rotat-

How We Tested

Cell phone tests are amongst the most subjective because there are fewer measurable parameters. For instance, would you choose a phone with hard-to-press keys and nice earphones, or vice-versa? It's therefore mostly about features. We divided the features into sub-sections:

1. Design and Ergonomics, where we looked at form factor, build quality, weight, ease of use of the UI, the ergonomics of the keypad, and such.
2. Basic phone features, such as support for network bands, display resolution and colours, the OS, support for installing Java applications, address book capacity, and Internet and connectivity options.
3. Memory: internal capacity, expandability, type of card slot, hot-swappable or not, etc.
4. Camera: still image resolution, auto-focus, flash, lens protection, available modes, etc.
5. Multimedia: Audio player characteristics such as different formats and whether equalisers are supported, audio formats supported, FM Radio, and such.
6. Other, extra features such as voice recorder, voice dialling, speaker phone, talk / standby time.

7. Accessories: Hands-free, data cable, memory card, and more.

Under Performance, we looked at aspects such as signal reception, voice clarity from the earpiece, speakerphone, and the hands-free microphone, processing speed, and quality of captured images and video. For the signal reception test, we chose three locations in our building: one with maximum signal strength, the second with medium signal strength, and the third with almost no signal. We noted the ability of the phone to hold on to the signal in these three zones, and rated them accordingly.

For the voice clarity test, we chose a location with maximum signal strength. The hands-free microphone test gauged the ability of the mic to separate the user's voice from the ambient sound. The response of the menus to key-presses was noted, and also the bootup time of the phone without a SIM card; this constituted the speed test. Photos and videos were shot in well-lit locations for the photo and video quality test; zoom was not used, and the default settings were maintained. The quality of captured photo and video was, naturally, a subjective test. We did, however, consider the opinions of multiple reviewers.